

Supreme Court of Florida

No. AOSC20-77
*Corrected*¹

IN RE: FLORIDA COURTS E-FILING PORTAL STANDARDS

ADMINISTRATIVE ORDER

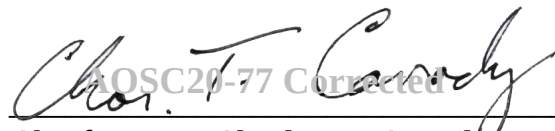
In In re: Statewide Standards for Electronic Access to the Courts, Fla.

Admin. Order No. AOSC09-30 (July 1, 2009), this Court adopted the Florida Supreme Court Standards for Electronic Access to the Courts, which define the requirements to electronically file documents in the state courts. In 2012, this Court adopted amendments to the Florida Rules of Court to implement mandatory electronic filing procedures for all documents filed in the state courts. In 2013, attorneys were required to file documents with the trial and appellate courts by electronic transmission through the Florida Courts E-Filing Portal (Portal) and clerks' offices were required to maintain electronic court records, convert paper documents to electronic documents, and electronically transmit the record on appeal.

1. This administrative order is issued to correct Standard 1.2.14 in the Florida Courts E-Filing Portal Standards that are referenced herein and attached hereto.

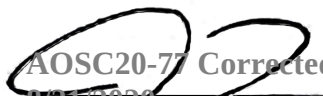
Considerable efforts have been and continue to be directed toward developing the infrastructure and policies necessary for parties to electronically file documents through the Portal, while simultaneously establishing mechanisms to accept and maintain documents electronically. Most recently, the Florida Courts Technology Commission proposed revisions to Florida Supreme Court Standards for Electronic Access to the Courts. Furthermore, the Commission proposed the removal of WordPerfect as an acceptable filing format to the Portal. The preferred filing format for documents filed through the Portal is PDF/A or a current equivalent. The Court finds that these revisions are necessary and appropriate and hereby adopts the Florida Courts E-Filing Portal Standards which supersede the 2009 standards. The revised standards are attached hereto and incorporated herein by reference and shall be effective upon the signing of this order.

DONE AND ORDERED at Tallahassee, Florida, on August 21, 2020.

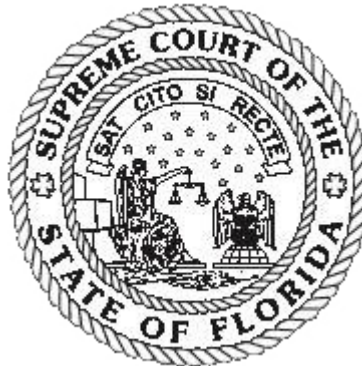


Chief Justice Charles T. Canady
AOSC20-77 Corrected 8/21/2020

ATTEST:



AOSC20-77 Corrected
8/21/2020
John A. Tomasino, Clerk of Court
AOSC20-77 Corrected 8/21/2020



Florida Courts E-Filing Portal Standards

Adopted June 2009

Adopted modifications August 2020

Version 19.0

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All electronic processes that involve the judiciary must be approved as defined by Florida Rule of Judicial Administration 2.236(b)(1) prior to implementation and must comply with the Americans With Disabilities Act (“ADA”).

1.0. E-FILING STANDARDS

The Florida Court’s E-Filing Portal (“Portal”) is governed by the Florida Courts E-Filing Authority. The Portal provides a central statewide point of access for filing court records and allows for interfaces with other existing statewide information systems.

Multiple pleadings, motions, etc. should not be combined into one single file, but rather each individual document should be uploaded via the Portal document submission process.

1.1 FILER AND DOCUMENT STANDARDS

1.1.1 Electronic Transmission and Filing of Documents

With the establishment of the Florida Courts E-Filing Portal, the Florida Courts have a centralized state-wide e-filing system. On June 21, 2012, the Supreme Court issued opinions approving recommendations to require e-filing by attorneys and e-service.

1.1.2 Document Filing

The Portal will accept new filings in Word, PDF, and PDF/A formats. The preferred format for filing is the PDF/A format where original document intelligence has been maintained.

Documents filed through the Portal will be provided to the clerk in PDF/A format when the clerk is able to receive and store a PDF/A document as follows:

- Documents filed in an approved PDF/A format will be provided to the clerk as originally filed.
- Documents filed in Word format will be converted to an approved PDF/A format.
- Documents filed in other searchable PDF formats will be converted to an approved PDF/A format.
- Documents filed in other non-searchable PDF formats will be rasterized (i.e., converted into bitmap file format) as an approved PDF/A format.
- Digital signatures and digital notarizations will not be passed or maintained by the Portal.

1.1.3 Size of Filing

A single submission, whether consisting of a single document or multiple documents, shall not exceed 50 megabytes (50 MB) in size.

1.1.4 Document Format

1.1.4.1 Document Page Requirements

All electronically filed documents should be legibly typewritten or printed on only one side of letter sized (8 ½ by 11 inch) paper; should have one-inch margins on all sides and on all pages and pages should be numbered consecutively; shall be filed in a format capable of being electronically searched and printed; should be filed in black and white; reduction of legal-size (8 ½ by 14 inches) documents to letter size (8 ½ by 11 inches) is prohibited; documents that are to be recorded in the public records of any county shall leave a 3-inch by 3-inch space at the top right-hand corner of the first page and a 1-inch by 3-inch space at the top right-hand corner on each subsequent page blank and reserved for use by the clerk of court.

1.1.4.2 Scanned Documents

Scanned documents should be scanned using Optical Character Recognition (“OCR”). Scanning process should use a minimum resolution of 300 DPI. Documents should be electronically signed as defined in [1.1.8, Electronic Signatures](#).

Deviation from these guidelines may result in the submitted filing being moved to the Correction Queue by the Clerk with the filer being notified via email and requested to correct the issue(s) with the document(s) and resubmit the filing.

1.1.5 Requirements for Individual Filers

1.1.5.1 Embedded Hyperlinks

Hyperlinks embedded within a filing should refer only to information within the same document, or to external documents or information sources that are reasonably believed to be trustworthy and stable over long periods of time. Hyperlinks should not be used to refer to external documents or information sources likely to change.

1.1.5.2 Exhibits

Multiple exhibits can be filed in one submission as long as each exhibit is accompanied by a cover page and does not exceed submission file size. On each cover page, the number of pages should be noted for that exhibit. To the extent an exhibit exceeds the size limitation, each portion shall be separately described as being a portion of the whole exhibit (e.g., Exhibit A, Part 1 of 5, Part 2 of 5, etc.).

1.1.5.3 Confidentiality and Sensitive Information

The Portal shall provide the following warning before documents are submitted through the Portal, “WARNING: As an attorney or self-represented filer, you are responsible to protect confidential information under Florida Rules of Judicial Administration [2.420](#) and [2.425](#). Before you file, please ensure that you have complied with these rules, including the need to complete a Notice of Confidential Information form or motion required under Rule [2.420](#) regarding confidential information. Your failure to comply with these rules may subject you to sanctions.”

1.1.6 File Name Standards

The following special characters are not allowed in a file name:

- Quotation mark (")
- Number sign (#)
- Percent (%)
- Ampersand (&)
- Asterisk (*)
- Colon (:)
- Angle brackets (less than, greater than) (< >)
- Question mark (?)
- Backslash (\)
- Slash (/)
- Braces (left and right) ({ })
- Pipe (|)
- Tilde (~)
- Period (.) The filer should not add an extension. The application will add it automatically.

In addition, file names cannot exceed 150 bytes in length, including spaces. Spaces must be counted as three (3) bytes each.

1.1.7 Retransmission of Electronic Filing

If, within 24 hours after filing information electronically, the filer discovers that the version of the document available for viewing through the Electronic Case Filing System is incomplete, garbled or otherwise does not depict the document as transmitted, the filer shall notify the Clerk of Court immediately and retransmit the filing if necessary.

1.1.8 Electronic Signatures

1.1.8.1 Signatures of Registered Users

A submission by a registered user is not required to bear the electronic image of the handwritten signature or an encrypted signature of the filer. Electronic signatures may be used in place of a handwritten signature unless otherwise prohibited by law. The information contained in the signature block shall meet the following required elements defined in Rule [2.515](#), Florida Rules of Judicial Administration Electronic signature formats of s/, /s or /s/ are acceptable.

Attorney Example

s/ John Doe
Bar Number 12345
123 South Street
City, FL 12345
Telephone: (123) 123-4567
Email Address

ProSe Example

s/ Jane Doe
123 North Street
City, FL 12345
Telephone: (123) 123-4567
Email Address

1.1.8.2 Multiple Attorneys of Record Signatures

When a filing requires the signatures of two or more attorneys of record:

The filing attorney shall initially confirm that the content of the document is acceptable to all attorneys required to sign the document and shall obtain the signatures of all attorneys on the document. For this purpose, physical, facsimile, or electronic signatures are permitted.

The filing attorney then shall file the document electronically, indicating the signatories, (*e.g.*, “s/ Jane Doe,” “/s John Smith,” “/s/ Jane Doe Smith,” etc.) for each attorney’s signature.

1.1.8.3 Judge Signature

Judges are authorized to electronically sign all orders and judgments. If digitized signatures of judges are stored, they are to be placed at a minimum 256-bit encryption and protected by user authentication.

1.1.8.3.1 Security

An electronic signature of a judge shall be accompanied by a date, time stamp, and the case number. The date, time stamp, and case number shall appear as a watermark through the signature to prevent copying the signature to another document. The date, time stamp, and case number shall also appear below the signature and not be obscured by the signature. When possible or required, the case number should be included also. Applications that store digitized signatures must store signatures in compliance with [FIPS 140-2](#).

1.1.8.3.2 Functionality

The ability to affix a judicial signature on documents must include functionality that would improve the process. This functionality at a minimum should include the following:

1. The ability to prioritize documents for signature.
2. Allow multiple documents to be reviewed and signed in a batch in addition to individually.
3. The judge must have the ability to review and edit, reject, sign and file documents.
4. Have a standard signature block size on the document.
5. Allow forwarding of queued documents to another judge for signature if the primary judge is unavailable.

6. After documents are signed or rejected, they should be removed from the queue.
7. Have the ability to electronically file the signed documents into the case management system to be electronically distributed to all appropriate parties.

1.1.8.4 Clerk Signature

Unless otherwise required by law, Clerks and Deputy Clerks are authorized to electronically sign any documents that require the signature of the clerk, subject to the same security requirements that apply to a judge signature under standard [1.1.8.3](#).

1.2 PORTAL FUNCTIONALITY

1.2.1 Minimum Functionality

1. Single statewide login.
2. Single Portal for attorneys as mandated per administrative order.
3. Process for non-attorneys and for self-represented users to access the system (e.g., state agencies, local agencies, law enforcement, mediators, process servers, etc.).
4. Uniform authentication method.
5. Single point of access for filing and service.
6. Consolidated electronic notification.
7. Process for local validation.
8. Automated interface with other e-filing systems as outlined in Portal documentation.
9. Utilize the approved XML ECF Standards at <https://docs.oasis-open.org/legalxml-court filing/ecf/v5.0/cs01/ecf-v5.0-cs01.pdf>.
10. Accommodate bi-directional transmissions to and from courts.
11. Integrate with other established statewide systems.
12. Accept electronic forms of payment.
13. All court-based e-filing processes will use Internet-based open standards.

1.2.2 Electronic Filing Envelope

The Portal shall generate an electronic e-filing envelope for each submission. The e-filing envelope must comply with current rules of procedure and with e-filing envelope requirements established by the Florida Courts Technology Commission (“FCTC”) for each division and court type. These requirements can be found at <http://www.flcourts.org/resources-and-services/court-technology/efiling/>.

The e-filing envelope shall be in XML format and contain the data elements needed to support the filing, indexing, docketing, calendaring, accounting, reporting, document development, case management, case maintenance and other necessary functions of the court. The Portal shall prompt the filer for all relevant information, identifying each data element as required or optional.

1.2.3 Portal Time Stamp

Date and time stamp formats must include a single line detailing the name of the court or Portal and shall not include clerk seals. Date stamps must be 8 numerical digits separated by slashes with 2 digits for the month, 2 digits for the date, and 4 digits for the year. Time stamps must be formatted in 12-hour time frames with a.m. or p.m. included.

The Portal's official file stamp date and time shall be affixed in the upper left-hand corner in Eastern Time. The Florida Supreme Court and District Courts of Appeal stamps shall be on the left margin readable horizontally. Any administrative agency stamp shall be in the right margin and readable horizontally. The clerk's stamp for circuit and county courts shall be in the bottom of the document.

1.2.4 Electronic Notification of Receipt

All submissions must generate an acknowledgment message that is transmitted to the filer to indicate that the portal has received the document.

At a minimum the acknowledgment must include the date and time the submission was received which is the official filing date/time.

1.2.5 Review by Clerk of Court

When information has been submitted electronically to the Clerk of Court's Office, via the Florida Courts E-Filing Portal, the Clerk of Court will review the filed document and determine whether it contains the required information for placement into the clerk's case maintenance system.

If, during the local document receiving process, a determination is made that the filed document conflicts with any court rules or standards, then the clerk shall place the filed document into a correction queue. A filing may be placed in a correction queue for any reason that prevents the filing from being accepted into the clerk's case maintenance system ("CMS"), e.g., documents that cannot be associated with a pending case; a corrupt file¹; or an incorrect filing fee.

Once placed in a correction queue, the clerk shall attempt to contact the filer using the filer's registered email address and ask the filer to correct the identified issue(s) and resubmit. If not corrected, the filing will remain in a correction queue for no more than 5 (five) business days, after which time the filing will be moved to the abandoned filing queue.

1.2.6 Docket Numbering

The sequence numbers would not be included in the interface between the Portal and the local clerk CMS and would not be provided to the filer as part of the e-filing notification process.

1.2.7 Security

The Portal shall provide initial screening and protection against unauthorized network intrusions, viruses, and attacks for all filings. The Portal shall be isolated from other court networks or applications. Software and security devices such as antivirus software, firewalls, access control lists, filters, and monitoring software must be used by the Portal to provide this initial protection

¹ Document(s) that cannot be opened or read

to court networks.

Computers that receive and accept filings from the Portal must be protected against unauthorized network intrusion, viruses, and attacks. These computers interface with the local CMS to accept e-filings. Software and security devices such as antivirus software, firewalls, access control lists, filters, and monitoring software must be used to protect the local court systems.

1.2.8 Filing Process

The Portal shall support both a single session filing process and a system-to-system process.

1.2.9 Submission Validation

The Portal shall validate each submission to detect any discrepancies (e.g., incomplete data or unacceptable document type) or other problems (e.g., viruses) prior to transmission to the Clerk. The Portal will return a submission to the correction queue if a virus is detected within the submission or if one or more of the documents in the submission is corrupt. The Portal will email the filer immediately if the Portal detects discrepancies or other problems with the submission, based on technical issues. The validation rules will be specific to the type of submission (for example: new case initiation as opposed to filings in an existing case).

1.2.10 Adding a Party

The Portal shall facilitate the addition of parties after the initial pleading is filed.

1.2.11 Confidentiality and Sensitive Information

The Portal shall provide the following warning before documents are submitted through the Portal, “WARNING: As an attorney or self-represented filer, you are responsible to protect confidential information under Florida Rules of Judicial Administration [2.420](#) and [2.425](#). Before you file, please ensure that you have complied with these rules, including the need to complete a Notice of Confidential Information form or motion required under Rule [2.420](#) regarding confidential information. Your failure to comply with these rules may subject you to sanctions.”

1.2.12 Emergency Filing

The Portal must provide a mechanism to indicate that a filing is an emergency.

1.2.13 System Availability and Recovery Planning

Computer systems that are used for e-filings must protect electronically filed documents against system and security failures during periods of system availability. Additionally, contingencies for system failures and disaster recovery mechanisms must be established. Scheduled downtime for maintenance and updates should be planned, and a notification shall be provided to filers in advance of the outage. Planned outages shall occur outside normal business hours as determined by the Chief Judicial Administrative Officer of the Court. E-filing systems shall comply with the security and backup policies created by the Florida Courts Technology Commission.

Plan 1: Contingency Plan

Timeframe: Immediate - during normal working hours.

Scope: Localized system failures while court is still open and operational. This plan will also be put into operation when Continuity of Operations (“COOP”) and Disaster Plans are implemented.

Operational Levels: Levels of operation will be temporarily limited and may be conducted in electronic or manual processes. Since court will still be open, this plan must address how documents will be received while the system is down.

Objectives:

- Allow the court to continue with minimum delays by providing a temporary alternate solution for access to court files.
- Conduct tests to verify the restoration process.
- Have local and local off-site backup of the operating system, application software, and user data available for immediate recovery operations.
- Identify areas where redundancy is required to reduce downtime and provide for “hot” standby equipment that can be utilized in the event the Contingency Plan is activated.

Plan 2: Business Continuity/Disaster Recovery

Timeframe: Disaster dependent, varies.

Scope: Declared disasters either local or regional that impact the geographic area.

Operational Levels: Temporarily unavailable or limited until facilities are deemed functional or alternate facilities can be established. Mission Essential Functions as defined in the Supreme Court’s COOP for the affected area must be addressed in the designated priorities and timeframes.

Objectives:

- Allow court operations to recover in the existing location or alternate facility.
- Provide cooperative efforts with impacted entities to establish access to court files and allow for the continuance of court proceedings.
- Provide in the Contingency Plan a temporary method to meet or exceed Mission Essential Functions identified in the Supreme Court’s COOP.
- Provide another tier level of recoverability by having a backup copy of the operating system, application software, and user data in a protected environment outside of the local area not subject to the same risks as the primary location for purposes of recovery according to standards approved by the FCTC.
- This plan may provide another out-of-state tier for data backup provided that the non-local in-state tier is established.

1.2.14 Document Filing

The Portal will accept new filings in Word, PDF, and PDF/A formats. The preferred format for filing is the PDF/A format where original document intelligence has been maintained.

Documents filed through the Portal will be provided to the clerk in PDF/A format when the clerk is able to receive and store a PDF/A document as follows:

- Documents filed in an approved PDF/A format will be provided to the clerk as originally filed.
- Documents filed in Word format will be converted to an approved PDF/A format.
- Documents filed in other searchable PDF formats will be converted to an approved PDF/A format.
- Documents filed in other non-searchable PDF formats will be rasterized (i.e., converted into bitmap file format) as an approved PDF/A format.
- Digital signatures and digital notarizations will not be passed or maintained by the Portal.

1.2.15 Electronic Notarization

Electronic notarization is authorized as provided in Florida Statute [117.021](#).

2.0 ELECTRONIC COURT RECORDS CUSTODIAN STANDARDS

Electronic court records custodians are responsible for the storage, processing, security, availability, accessibility, and integrity of electronic court records (i.e., images and data) under their care.

These standards are minimum standards. If a custodian stores court-related data from another jurisdiction or agency with stricter requirements, the custodian must comply with the stricter standards for that data.

2.1 Court Document Format

Custodians shall ensure that:

- Electronic documents that are part of a court file (i.e., the record copy) are stored in the PDF/A format.
- This is a day-forward standard.
- Upon implementation of the PDF/A standard for incoming filings, existing electronic documents may remain in their current format(s) if the clerk maintenance system (CMS) is capable of managing multiple file formats.
- The record copy of each electronic court document retains the original document intelligence (i.e., as filed with the Portal) with the exception of features that use a digital hash. For example, digital signatures and electronic notarizations may be flattened and the certificates invalidated as the document moves through the filing process.

2.2 ADA Compliance

Custodians of electronic court documents are not responsible for adding ADA-compliance features to documents that they did not originate. However, custodians are required to follow acceptable ADA practices for access to court documents.

2.3 Court Records Redaction

Custodians shall ensure that confidential information contained within a court record is redacted prior to release or review of the record as defined by Fla. R. Jud. Admin. 2.420. Redaction software which identifies confidential information may be used; however, a manual process must also exist to identify confidential information which may not be readily identified by an automated redaction process or for case types/documents that are available upon request.

Redacted copies of electronic court documents are not required to retain the original document intelligence. These copies may be flattened to accommodate existing redaction workflow processes.

2.4 Court Records Storage

Custodians shall ensure that:

- All court data under their care is stored in the United States. This includes the record copy and all backup and archival copies.
- The production data or backup copy will reside in a hardened (CAT 5) facility. If a hardened (CAT 5) facility is unavailable, a tertiary copy (redundant backup) will also be maintained in its own off site, independent facility. The production electronic court records and at least one copy of the backup(s) shall not be housed in the same building.
- Agreements with third party vendors for Cloud or offsite acknowledge the confidentiality of electronic court data they store and prohibit data mining and other access/use of the data for any purpose other than to make the data accessible to the custodian.
- All copies of court data must be readily available to the custodian.
- Any known breach, or other malicious event, is reported to the chief judge or his/her designee and the Chief Information Security Officer at the Office of the State Courts Administrator Office of Information Technology as part of the custodian's Computer Security Incident Response plan.
- Physical and electronic data transfer processes conform to the confidentiality and security guidelines set forth in the Data Exchange Standards.

2.5 Court Records Backups and Archival

Custodians shall ensure that:

- Electronic court records in their care are securely backed-up and any backup data stored at a third-party location must also be encrypted. The custodian of the electronic court records shall have exclusive access to the encryption key. In instances where vendors are supporting appliances onsite and are required to maintain an encryption key, the custodian will have operational policies and procedures that serve as a control prohibiting vendor access without invitation and monitoring.
- Random sample testing is performed annually to verify that backup data is accessible and recoverable.
- Archival copies are created in a manner that allows for presenting the information in the future without degradation, loss of content, or issues with software compatibility relative to the proper rendering of electronic documents.

3.0 CLERKS' CASE MAINTENANCE SYSTEM STANDARDS

3.1 Document Rendering

The clerk must render document images in searchable PDF/A format for viewer interfaces where the Court Application Processing System ("CAPS") does not already provide searchable documents.

3.2 Electronic Filing Envelope

The Portal shall generate an electronic e-filing envelope for each submission. The e-filing envelope must comply with current rules of procedure and with e-filing envelope requirements established by the FCTC for each division and court type. These requirements can be found at <http://www.flcourts.org/resources-and-services/court-technology/efiling/>.

The e-filing envelope shall be in XML format and contain the data elements needed to support the filing, indexing, docketing, calendaring, accounting, reporting, document development, case management, case maintenance and other necessary functions of the court. The Portal shall prompt the filer for all relevant information, identifying each data element as required or optional.

3.3 Clerk's Time Stamp

Date and time stamp formats must include a single line detailing the name of the court or Portal and shall not include clerk seals. Date stamps must be 8 numerical digits separated by slashes with 2 digits for the month, 2 digits for the date, and 4 digits for the year. Time stamps must be formatted in 12-hour time frames with a.m. or p.m. included.

The Portal's official file stamp date and time shall be affixed in the upper left-hand corner in Eastern Time. The Florida Supreme Court and District Courts of Appeal stamps shall be on the left margin readable horizontally. Any administrative agency stamp shall be in the right margin and readable horizontally. The clerk's stamp for circuit and county courts shall be in the bottom of the document.

3.4 Docket Numbering

- At a minimum, the local clerk CMS would assign and store a sequence number for each docket entry that contains a document on each case. The sequence number would be unique only within each case. For example, each case will start with 1, 2, 3, etc. and increment by 1.
- The sequence number would be displayed on each document/docket display screen in the local clerk CMS and any associated access systems (websites, etc.)
- Each assigned document/docket sequence number would need to remain static for each case once assigned. If documents/dockets are inserted, then the sequence numbers would not necessarily align with the dates for the documents/docket. As long as they are unique within each case this would be allowed.
- The sequence number may be implemented on a "go-forward" basis if necessary; sequence numbers are not required for historical documents/dockets.

- The sequence numbers are only assigned and stored in the local clerk CMS. The sequence numbers would not be included in the interface between the Portal and the local clerk CMS and would not be provided to the filer as part of the e-filing notification process.
- This requirement does not apply to legacy CMS applications which have a known end date.

4.0 ADA AND TECHNOLOGY COMPLIANCE

All Court technology must comply with the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA”).